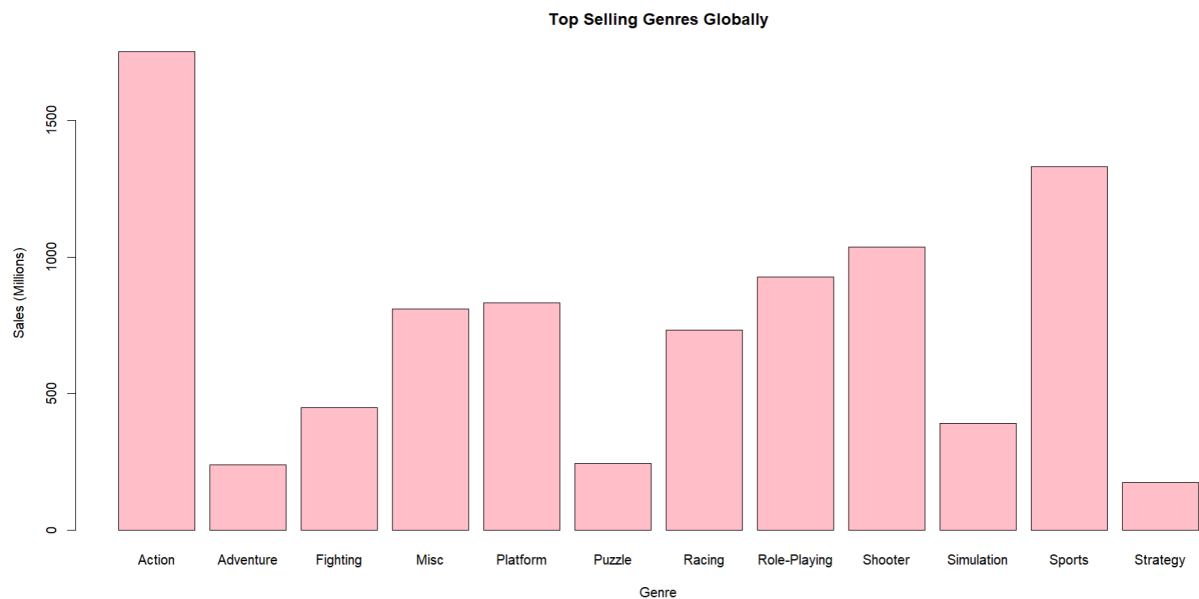


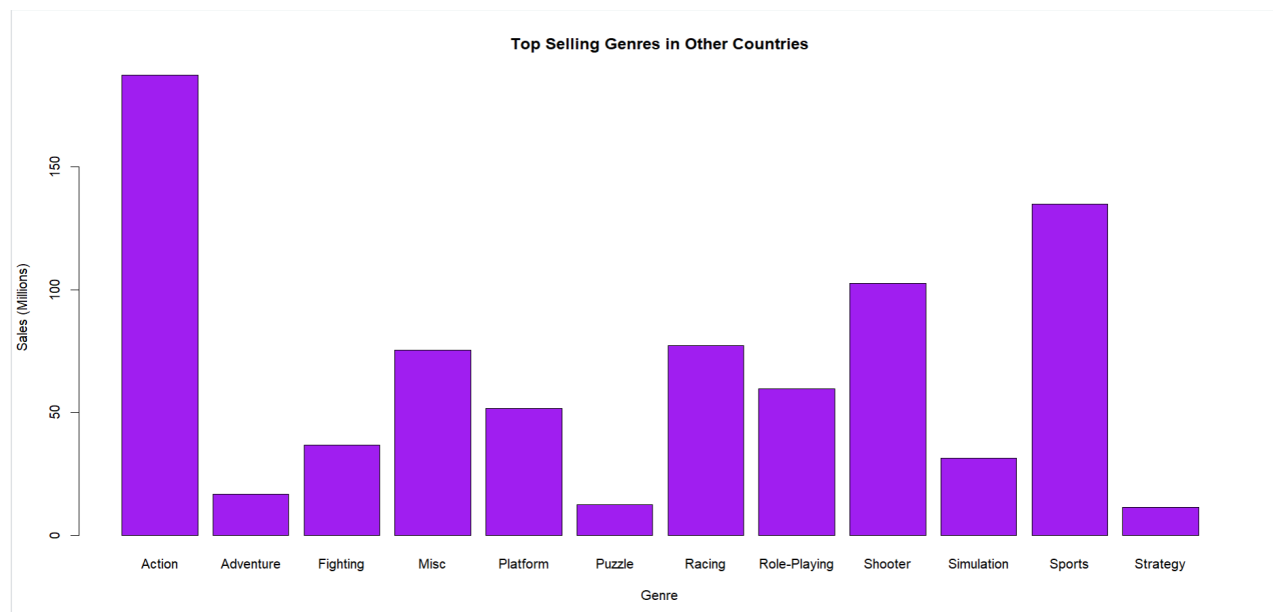
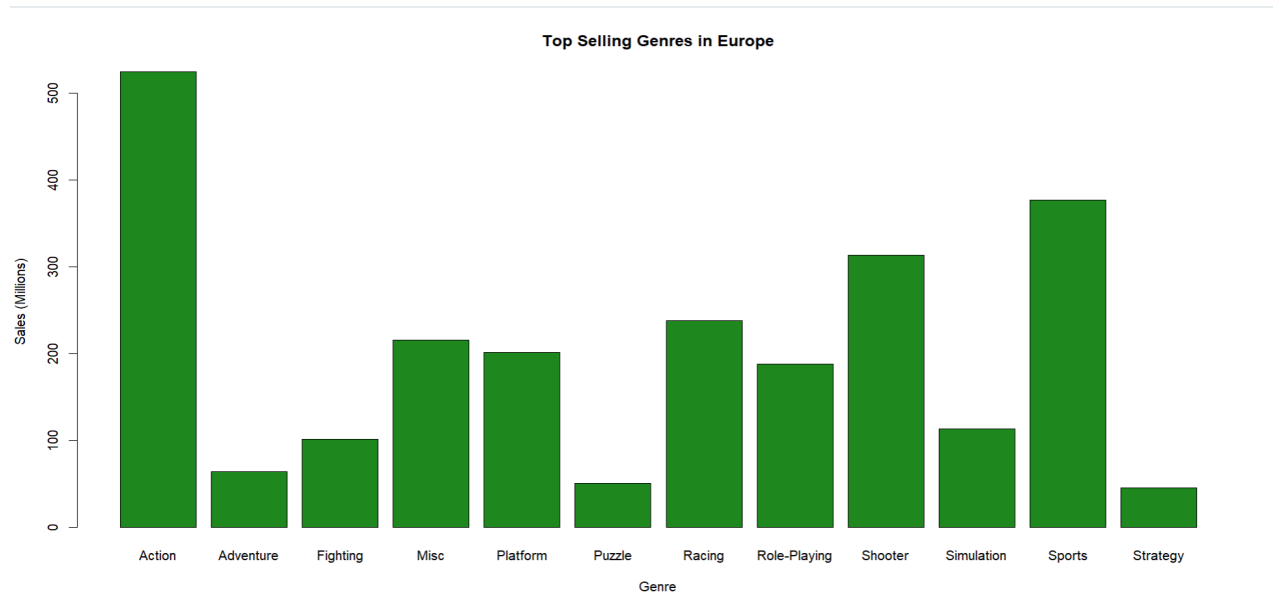
The *Best* Video Game Genre of All Time, and Why It Is *Not* the Most Popular in Japan

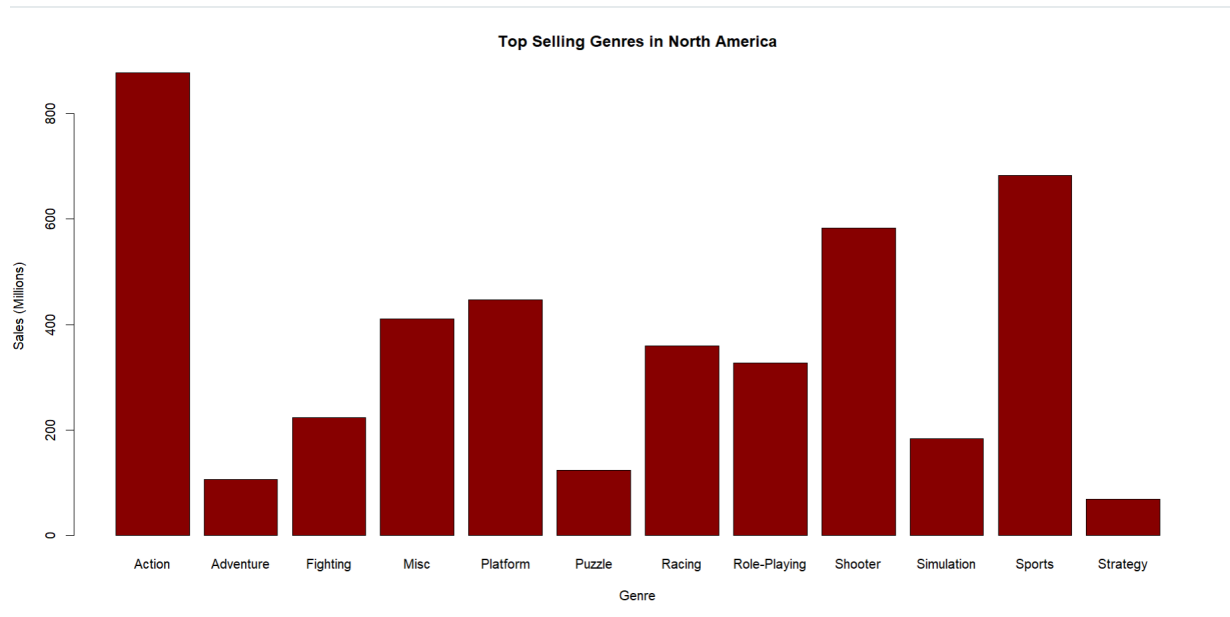
By Nishka Pandya

With the rise of technology, video games have experienced significant growth in popularity and sales over the past two decades. Many people who play video games may have a passion for creating successful video games. But the ultimate question is, what makes a video game successful? How have certain popular publishers, such as Nintendo, made their games successful? To understand this, we have to understand regional preferences, which are contradictory and surprising. I analyzed a dataset related to video game sales, and here is what I found.

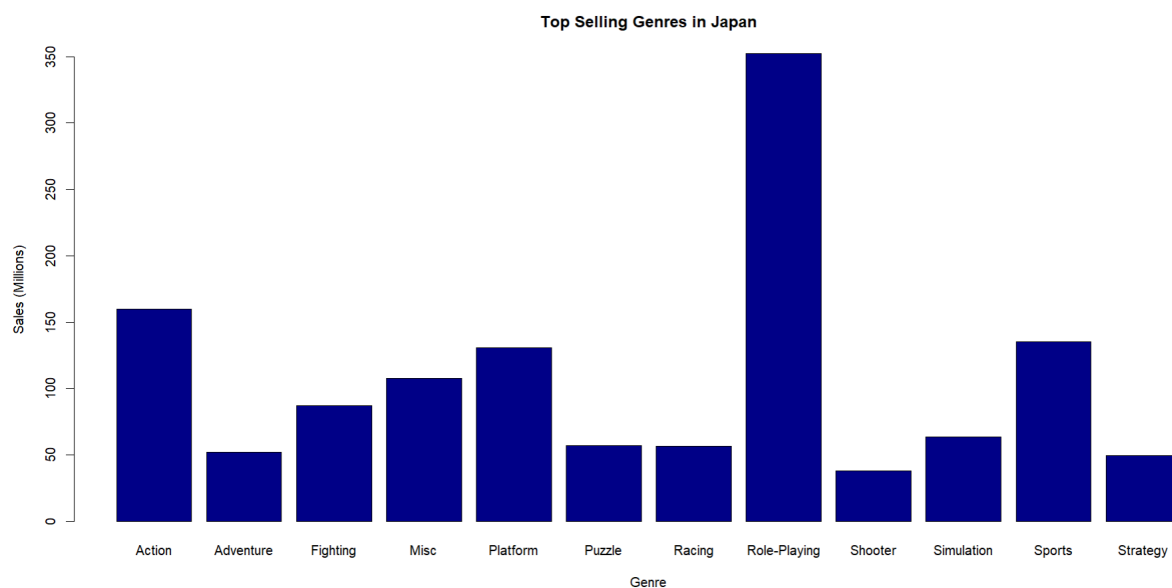


Globally, action is the most popular genre of all time. A popular action game is Grand Theft Auto, developed by Take-Two Interactive. Following action are sports and shooters.





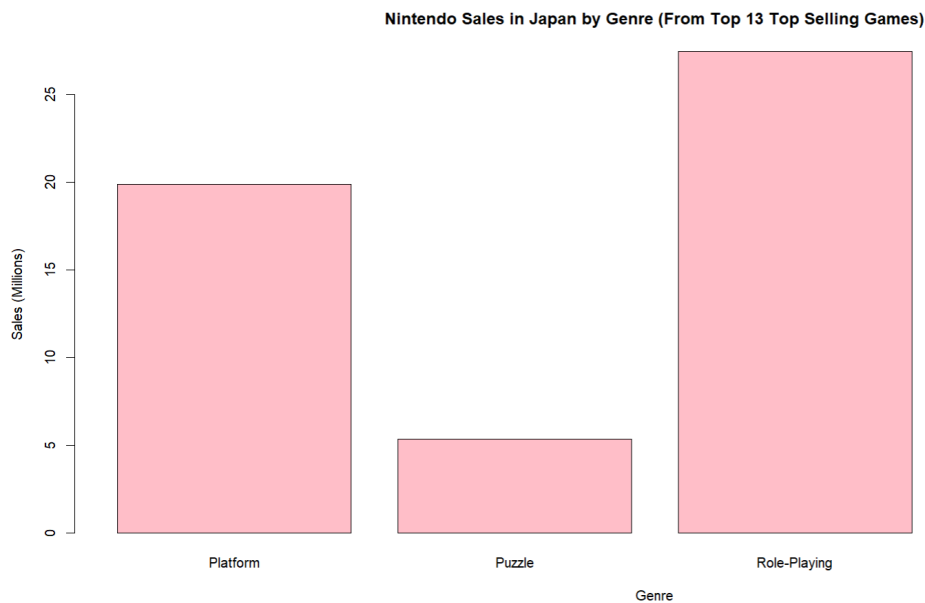
In North America, Europe, and many other countries, the popularity of the video game genre is similar to the global genre popularity. However, in the North American and European video game market, platform games are more popular than role-playing games, while globally, role-playing games sell more. In North America and Europe, action, sports, and shooter games dominate. It may seem that since Japan is a top video game market, it would also sell action video games the highest since globally it sells the highest, but that data reveals otherwise.



Data shows that role-playing games make up significantly more of video game sales in Japan, followed by action, which sells only half of what role-playing games sell. Sports games also

don't sell as much. This serves as an example for developers looking to create a new game: not every country, despite being a major contributor to the video game market, is primarily into action. According to the dataset, action games sold in Japan make up only nine percent of total global sales of action games.

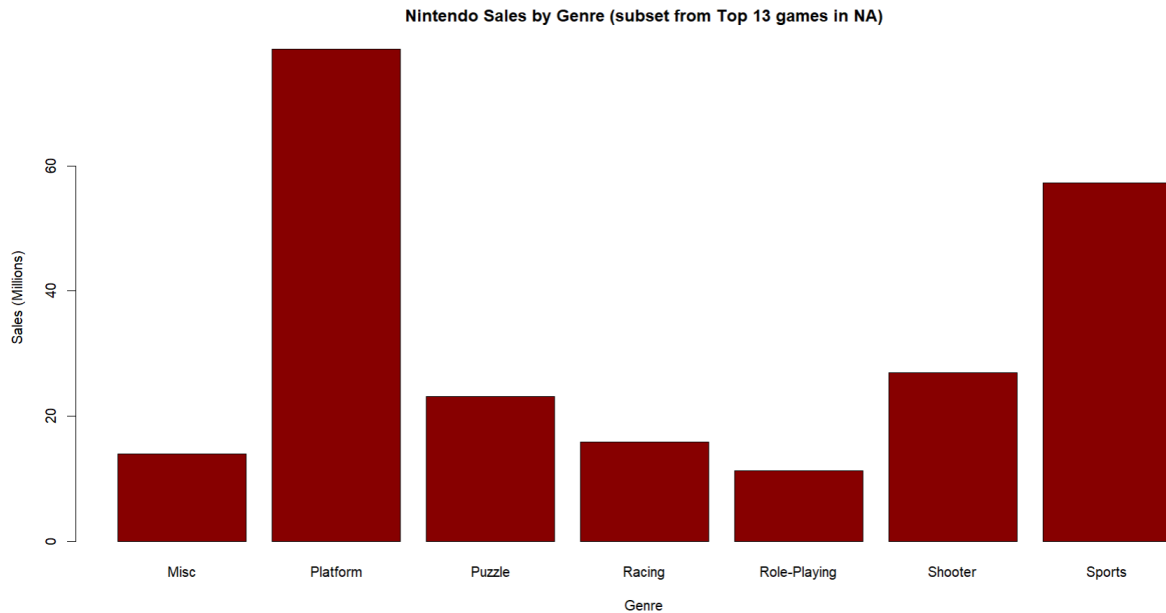
Nintendo Solves Japan's Key



In this dataset, Nintendo has the most video game sales. It may be feasible to think that, because action is globally popular and Nintendo is also a popular publisher, Nintendo must be producing the best-selling action games. That was something I assumed. However, looking at the data, it is exactly the opposite, especially when it comes to Japan.

I looked at a subset of the top 13 best-selling video games in Japan and noticed that Nintendo mostly dominated. From that list, I looked to see a potential factor that could have made Nintendo successful. I looked and saw that Nintendo sold high in RPG games, followed by platform games, as seen in the barplot above. Maybe this answers the question of how Nintendo gained high sales in Japan; it is because they created games catered to Japan's interests. This led me to think that a publisher catering to a country's genre can play a role in becoming a best-selling publisher.

Nintendo Does the Exact *Opposite* in North America



While Nintendo dominated the top 13 games in Japan, in North America, Nintendo also dominated the top 13 games but for different reasons. In Japan, Nintendo dominated by following Japan's most popular genre, RPG. However, in North America, Nintendo's action games did not make the top 13 games. Instead, Nintendo heavily dominated because of its platform and sports games. This is counterintuitive to the other pattern: in Japan, Nintendo's success was based on following Japan's favorite genre, while in North America, Nintendo's action games did not dominate as much as its platform and sports games. Maybe genre is not everything.